

Book Review

BENSO, SILVIA and BRIAN SCHROEDER, eds., *Between Nihilism and Politics: The Hermeneutics of Gianni Vattimo*, SUNY Press, 2010, 270 pp., \$24.95 (pbk), ISBN: 978-1438432847.

It has not been easy to follow Vattimo lately. After building his reputation in the 1980s thanks to the notion of “weak thought” that he added to the lexicon of Continental Philosophy, he has applied different degrees of “weakness” to ontology, ethics, theology, and politics. The flexibility of the weak thought model has allowed him to be an ontologist who does not believe in ontology, a seeker of truth who does not believe that there is such a thing as non-contingent truth, a nihilist who believes in the redemptive power of merciful nihilism, a moralist who does not believe in moral systems, a Catholic who does not believe in God, and a Marxist who does not subscribe to anything that Marxist-derived ideologies have accomplished but nonetheless still professes a vague belief in Marxism’s Second Coming. It would be easy, in fact, to portray Vattimo as the quintessential fashionable liberal who is too smart to believe his own ideas, a perfect foil for a conservative rebuke. In point of fact, a recent anti-Vattimo backlash has not come from conservative critics but from Vattimo’s own ranks when his former pupil Maurizio Ferraris published his *Manifesto del nuovo realismo* (2012), in which he attacked the relativism of his former teacher in the name of a rediscovered notion of objective reality. It cannot be denied that Vattimo’s recent declarations about the disappearance of truth and the wonders of relativism have aroused the suspicion that weak thought is to philosophy what Diet Coke is to Coca-Cola. In the end, the assumption of sugar-substitutes may turn out to be a more serious health hazard than the real thing. Ferraris’ philosophical “parricide,” however, although skilled enough to get the attention of newspapers’ cultural supplements, is too unsophisticated to stand against Vattimo’s vast body of work, where there is more to be found than just a decaffeinated version of post-Heideggerian metaphysics.

Now that more of his books have appeared in English translation (after a true editorial odyssey, the *Weak Thought* volume was published in its entirety only in 2013), the fourteen essays on Vattimo included in *Between Nihilism and Politics* can be measured against a more substantial body of work made available to the English-speaking readership. The collection is divided in three sections, “Hermeneutics and Nihilism,” “Metaphysics and Religion,” and “Politics and Technology.” It is not easy to single out chapters, as they are all of consistently good quality. In the first section, Franca D’Agostini’s “Vattimo’s Theory of Truth” and Peter Carravetta’s “*Beyond Interpretation?*” manage to ask the most pressing questions about the philosopher’s recent turns. According to D’Agostini, Vattimo’s theory of truth is “an original mixture of historical coherentism and politically oriented pragmatism” (44). Carravetta, on the other hand, seems genuinely puzzled by the “swerve” that Vattimo has taken in the 1990s, *de facto* suggesting that Vattimo, in his embrace of post-modern and pre-modern stances at the same time, wants to have his cake and eat it too. It is true that Vattimo seems to have developed a no-drama philosophy. Nihilism is being stripped of tragedy, Christianity can do without the flesh and blood of Christ, and the negation of the violence inherent to origins ushers, rather miraculously, in a society based on charity. In the second section of the volume, Giovanna Borradori and Eduardo Mendieta do their best to show how Vattimo’s involvement with religion has indeed produced a body of work that anyone interested in secularization cannot dismiss. Borradori clarifies how,

according to Vattimo, “by descending on earth ... the Christian God inaugurated the interminable process of secularization” (138), and Mendieta points out that “it is the corrosive effects of both secularization and nihilism that allow for religion to return” (159), albeit with a liberating effect, because once religion has become completely secular, “one *can* believe, not because one *must* or *is* commanded” (our emphasis). In the third section of the volume the authors question the recent “revolutionary turn of weak thought” (Luca Bagetto, 198), which brings back radical political engagement after relativism apparently annihilated everything that was left of social commitment. Silvia Benso sees a clear utopian *élan* in Vattimo’s renewed approach to politics, with the *caveat* that utopia is now being channeled toward “continuity of resistance” (217) and not toward the “eschatological discontinuity” of classical utopian revolutions. Erik M. Vogt, in one of the most engaging chapters of the volume, acknowledges “the formidable task” of Vattimo’s attempt to articulate an “ontology of actuality,” yet he questions the absence of economics in Vattimo’s “pure politics” and summons Slavoj Žiždek to characterize Vattimo’s position with regard to technological post-modernity as a “regression” to a pre-symbolic state (233). In various degrees, all the authors recognize Vattimo’s role in postmodern philosophy, but the volume is far from being a pure exercise in praise—one more reason why it is likely to become essential for anyone who intends to tackle seriously with Vattimo’s legacy.

Reviewed by ALESSANDRO CARRERA
University of Houston, acarrera@central.uh.edu